



Ray of hope: After finishing bottom this season, Alpine will hope Formula One's sweeping 2026 reset offers a way back into contention. GETTY IMAGES

now have to cope with the ill-fated second seat alongside Max Verstappen in 2026, hoping to be the last man standing in the game of musical chairs. "For me, he was the top rookie of the season," Karun exclaimed. "I hope he doesn't suffer the same pain as all the others who've gone to Red Bull recently. He's a great kid. There's a real inner fire in him," he added.

Kick Sauber also climbed the constructors' ladder in its final season before rebranding as Audi's works team. Nico Hulkenberg finally put a full stop to the longest wait for a podium in F1 history, finishing third at the British Grand Prix in his 239th race start. Back-to-back feeder series champion Gabriel Bortoleto contributed 19 points, including four top-10 finishes in six races during the European leg.

Reset button

The forward strides made by the midfield will, however, be washed away by a wave of change as a new

era dawns in the top tier of single-seater motorsport. The 2026 regulations, focused largely on engine-related changes, will effectively clear the slate. Under the new statutes, the power unit will be 50 per cent electrical, up from the 15 to 20 per cent share that has defined the hybrid era since 2014. The MGU-H (Motor Generator Unit – Heat), which converted exhaust heat energy into electrical power, has also been removed.

"There is a huge challenge for teams to figure out how they'll charge these big batteries without the MGU-H. There's going to be a lot of emphasis on the software to get the right combination of electric and engine power for the whole lap," Karun explained.

"The drivers will not be able to drive at 100% all the time. They will have to be careful about using their energy. We're going to see a very different style of racing. The intelligent drivers will be the successful drivers next year," he added.

The renewed reliance on engines could tilt the balance towards traditional power unit manufacturers such as Mercedes and Ferrari, rather

than customer teams, when the cars roll out for the season-opening Australian Grand Prix.

"Someone will get the engine formula fantastically right, and some will get it fantastically wrong. I hope that we don't have big gaps, because we want everyone to be close together for the show," the former Red Bull junior opined. "We're going to see a lot of development in the first 18 months. What you see in Melbourne for the first race next year is not a guarantee. We'll see a lot of development and progression through the year," he added.

The former Hispania Racing Team and Lotus Racing driver also noted: "The FIA has created a system where, if a team is too far behind, they will get some dispensation to make some big changes. So, there'll be some games playing with all of that as well."

When the track opens for preseason testing in Bahrain in three months, midfield teams will hope the regulation reset acts as a catalyst for further progress. Because one backward step might be enough to send them tumbling down the pecking order.